Notions of selflessness and merit play an essential role in the discursive framing and logistical operations of Byama-so. The inspiration of Buddhism is evident in the language of merit (*kutho*), loving kindness (*myitta*), compassionate social action (*parahita*), and selfless intention (*sedana*) with which volunteers refer to and reflect on their work, especially at times of difficulty or exhaustion. For instance, blood donors are usually accompanied by a volunteer from these organizations who support and ideationally frame the experience of blood-giving as 'saving lives' and putting into practice the 'value of life' for the 'good of the nation' (see McCarthy forthcoming a). The same language recurs in the Pali blessings recited for donors when they make contributions to various Buddhist organizations, as well as on the stickers that cover the funeral vans and ambulances.

INFORMAL MECHANISMS OF RECIPROCITY

In addition to the role of Buddhist-imbued social institutions, there are also a variety of informal mechanisms of everyday redistribution and reciprocity that are deeply framed by Buddhist social morality. For instance, small giving celebrations are held when a family makes a donation to monks, or when a son becomes a novice monk for a period. Such charitable events, intimately tied to Buddhist economies of gift and merit, play an important role in the cultivation of more formal welfare networks in Buddhist communities. Donations are frequently offered to the hosts of these events by attendees to support many of the aforementioned welfare and social activities organized around monasteries, including ambulance services, health clinics, or Dhamma schools. The donations made at these social events are referred to with the same terminology of merit-making and loving intentions as more formal organizations. These events also solidify social ties across a wide range of spheres, with employers, teachers, neighbours, and monks all invited to attend and follow the procession or share in the meal.

Neighbourhood funeral associations use similar symbolism and language of merit-making to explain the support provided to families of the deceased. The majority of Taungoo's urban wards and rural villages have one of these loosely organized groups. Operating on a per-funeral basis, a number of inner-city groups have over 300 members, each of